

The Georgians were carrying corpses back: A former RT producer on how Georgia started the war in South Ossetia.



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In August 2008, Nikolai Baranov was a producer for the Russian television channel Russia Today. On the day the Georgian aggression began 13 years ago, he was in Georgia and personally witnessed tanks and infantry advancing on the sleeping Tskhinvali.

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Thirteen years after the war, former RT producer Nikolai Baranov clearly remembers Georgian troops advancing on South Ossetia, their tanks and aircraft shelling the city and its civilians. He witnessed it all with his own eyes.

He says that the Georgians have very carefully worked out the theme of promoting the campaign against Tskhinvali.

"As far as I know, some European company was working there, and it was they who started talking about a Russian attack. But I was personally present and saw everything that happened on the

ground. I watched the Georgians marching, saw them enter early in the morning of the 8th, and on the 9th, a reinforced tank company of up to a hundred men and up to 15 tanks entered. I witnessed it myself," says the journalist, a former military man.

Baranov says the Georgians attacked from three directions. He says there's no doubt the war began on the Georgian side.

He and his film crew tried to convey truthful information about what was really happening in South Ossetia.



Sladkov on the war in South Ossetia: The bullets that hit Vetchinov hit me

August 7, 2020, 7:41 PM

Their colleagues, who entered Tskhinvali together with the Russian army, tried to help them with this.

"RT broke through very clearly and told the whole world the truth. My colleague Ashraf was broadcasting to the Arab world. Russian media were entering Tskhinvali from the north. Moreover, they were ambushed. Denis Vetchinov was killed, and journalists Alexander Sladkov and Alexander Kots were wounded. In other words, weapons were used directly against journalists," says Baranov.

He also recalled footage of burning Tskhinvali, which Western media presented as footage of "Russia bombing the Georgian city of Gori." These images were filmed by his own crew.

"I lived in Gori for two days, and nothing was burning there. That's not true. Gori was completely calm. People were worried, of course, and some were upset that a Russian television company was in Gori while the Russians were defending Tskhinvali. But nothing was burning in Gori," the journalist said.

According to him, there were a lot of mobilized people there - ordinary villagers were put under arms, changed clothes, and they slept right in the hotel on the floor or in the central square.



"It's hard to say how many times I almost died": South Ossetia's deputy speaker on the 2008 war

August 7, 2021, 12:07 PM

On their third day working in the conflict zone, Russian journalists in Gori were "visited" by Georgian security services. They were treated with no ceremony. Baranov and his comrades were interrogated for nearly 12 hours.

"On August 10th, Georgian security services caught us. Some of my guys were beaten, especially the cameraman from North Ossetia, and interrogated. The interrogation lasted 12 hours. They asked us what we'd filmed, how, and whether we were spies. Then they sent us to Tbilisi to fly away. But from there, we went to Armenia. I'm a retired colonel, and at the time, I was very afraid that one of the guys would let it slip that I was a former General Staff officer. I would have been shot right there," the journalist recalls.

He says those who interrogated them spoke "perfect" Russian. And he knows for a fact that some of the instructors in the Georgian army were from Ukraine.

"We saw them firing point-blank at the city, at the peacekeepers, killing them directly, that's exactly how it happened. I saw MI-26s hitting the city directly. There's no other way to describe it. They ran out of ammunition and returned, and this went on for several hours. We filmed all this footage and sent it to RT, but it disappeared. I don't know how that happened," Baranov said.



The President of South Ossetia awarded Russian journalists in Moscow.

February 12, 2019, 3:08 PM

On the way back, he says, the Georgians were carrying the corpses of their soldiers.

"Bodies strewn with some kind of junk, some tables. I saw it myself. They were already running away from the Ossetian units on the second day," the journalist said.

In 2019, President Anatoly Bibilov presented **awards** to Russian journalists for their objective coverage of the August 2008 war. Among the recipients were Nikolai Baranov and his RT colleague Ashraf El Sabbah.